Let's start with a basic requirement of finding out the total number of books we have in stock (in the `books` index, in this case). Elasticsearch exposes a `_count` API to satisfy this requirement. It is pretty straightforward, as we see in the next section.

2.2.1 Counting documents

Knowing the total number of documents in an index is a requirement fulfilled by the `_count` API. Invoking the `_count` endpoint on the `books` index results in the number of documents persisted in that index.

Listing 2.3 Counting documents using the `_count` API

```
GET books/_count
```

Counting the number of books

This should return the response shown the in figure 2.9.

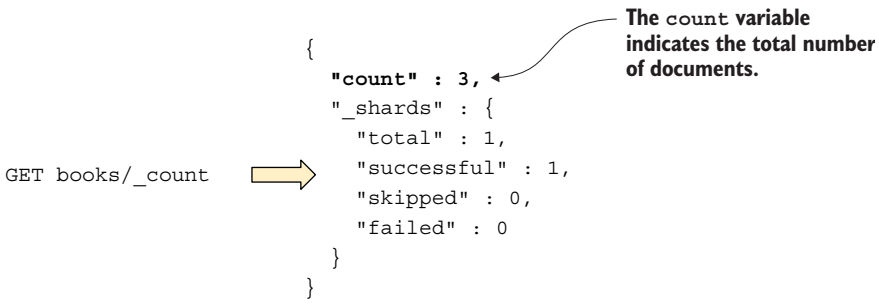


Figure 2.9 The JSON response for a `_count` API invocation

The highlighted count variable indicates the total number of documents in the `books` index. We can also use the same API to fetch from multiple indices at once, by adding comma-separated indices such as `GET books1,books2/_count`. (Note that if you execute this query right now, the system will throw an `index_not_found_exception` indicating that the `books2` index doesn't exist.)

We can fetch the number of documents in *all* indices, too, by issuing a `GET _count` call. This returns all the documents available, including system and hidden indices. In the next section, we use APIs to retrieve documents.

2.2.2 Retrieving documents

Just as we deposit money in our bank account, we indexed documents into Elasticsearch earlier. We now need to access these documents (just like we withdraw money from our bank account).

Every document that is indexed has a unique identifier; some identifiers are provided by us, and others are generated by Elasticsearch. Operations to retrieve